

Opinion of the Court

room to make reasonable but mistaken judgments about open legal questions.” *Ashcroft v. al-Kidd*, 563 U. S. 731, 743 (2011).

The Court’s cases provide additional instruction to define and implement that immunity. Whether qualified immunity can be invoked turns on the “objective legal reasonableness” of the official’s acts. *Harlow, supra*, at 819. And reasonableness of official action, in turn, must be “assessed in light of the legal rules that were clearly established at the time [the action] was taken.” *Anderson, supra*, at 639 (internal quotation marks omitted); see also *Mitchell*, 472 U. S., at 528. This requirement—that an official loses qualified immunity only for violating clearly established law—protects officials accused of violating “extremely abstract rights.” *Anderson, supra*, at 639.

The Fourth Amendment provides an example of how qualified immunity functions with respect to abstract rights. By its plain terms, the Amendment forbids unreasonable searches and seizures, yet it may be difficult for an officer to know whether a search or seizure will be deemed reasonable given the precise situation encountered. See *Saucier v. Katz*, 533 U. S. 194, 205 (2001) (“It is sometimes difficult for an officer to determine how the relevant legal doctrine, here excessive force, will apply to the factual situation the officer confronts”). For this reason, “[t]he dispositive question is ‘whether the violative nature of *particular* conduct is clearly established.’” *Mullenix v. Luna*, 577 U. S. 7, 12 (2015) (*per curiam*) (quoting *Ashcroft, supra*, at 742).

It is not necessary, of course, that “the very action in question has previously been held unlawful.” *Anderson, supra*, at 640. That is, an officer might lose qualified immunity even if there is no reported case “directly on point.” *Ashcroft, supra*, at 741. But “in the light of pre-existing law,” the unlawfulness of the officer’s conduct “must be apparent.” *Anderson, supra*, at 640. To subject officers to any broader liability would be to “disrupt the balance that our cases